



I LOSE INTEREST IN AND RESPECT FOR PLAYERS WHO DON'T GET INTO AND STAY IN TIP-TOP SHAPE. CRITICISM OF OVERWEIGHT PROFESSIONAL ATHLETES IS NOT 'BODY SHAMING'

interviewers sometimes ask absurd questions like "What is your strategy today?" Even the most inexperienced player won't answer that question.

Players who say "I have nothing to lose" — I'm not a psychologist, but these world-class athletes may be trying to lessen the pressure they

feel as big underdogs. Whatever the reason, this pre-match expression defies logic. Upsets — major and minor — occur every day at every level in tennis. But a player must embrace the underdog status — as 18-year-old qualifier Emma Raducanu did when she won the

Not the real deal: Players who fake injuries to break their opponent's momentum, unlike Zverev here (in pic, on the ground) infuriate opponents, test the goodwill of ATP and WTA physiotherapists, and disappoint tournament directors, TV networks, and spectators. GETTYIMAGES

2021 US Open — and not prepare for defeat with the nonsense that they have nothing to lose. Memo: we all have a winnable match to lose. So don't say it or even think it.

The 'house money' line — A corollary to the previous

rationalisation is the equally nonsensical claim by TV commentators: "He's playing on house money now." *Wiktionary* defines this expression as "To be in a situation where little or no personal risk can be incurred" and "To act as though little or no risk can be incurred." Commentators trot out this logical fallacy when an unheralded player or a heavy underdog pulls two or more upsets and then faces a much higher-ranked opponent. But, in fact, these underdogs who have increasing momentum and confidence not only have much to gain in the coming match but also much to lose—typically a berth in the semifinals or final.

Faking injuries — Players who fake injuries to break their opponent's momentum and to get rest when they are exhausted and then defend it by saying — "Everyone does it" — when everyone obviously doesn't. These bad guys infuriate